

Response to Pre-Review Comments

REB# 26-08-029

Re: 26-08-029 - Pre-Review Modifications Required

This is a pre-review; no memo is submitted to the REB. All corrections are in the revised protocol, recruitment email, informed consent document, and eForm. This document tracks what changed and where, for internal reference.

1 A. General Information

Where fixed: ethics-protocol.qmd, opening paragraph (line 21). Funding page on the eForm already shows Fund #587162 correctly; no change needed there.

582492 and 587162 are both legitimate CIHR numbers for this project. 587162 is the CIHR Project Grant - Priority Announcement: Pandemic Preparedness and Health Emergencies Research, approved, \$100,000, and the number entered as Fund # on the eForm. 582492 is the mainline Project Grant application under which the study was scientifically reviewed. Both appear on the CIHR Notice of Decision (22 July 2026).

2 B. Research Personnel

Where fixed: ethics-protocol.qmd, Recruitment and consent section (line 25). eForm Research Personnel page still needs Zachary Batist added: Postdoctoral Researcher, Department of Epidemiology, Biostatistics and Occupational Health.

The protocol states that the Scientific Director, Operations Manager, and Data Managers whose mailboxes form the email corpus are data subjects, not research team members, and that TCPS2 CORE training does not apply to them.

3 C. Funding and Other Reviews

Where fixed: no independent text needed; satisfied by the Consent Process revision (comment F).

The CIHR peer reviewers' and Scientific Officer's concerns about consent for individuals other than the mailbox holder are answered by the revised Consent Process section's TCPS2 Article 5.5A argument, including the impracticability of seeking consent from the broader population of email correspondents.

4 D. Study Information

Where fixed: ethics-protocol.qmd, Recruitment and consent section (line 29). eForm Total Sample Size field.

Over 100 partner studies $\times$ an estimated 2 to 3 contactable individuals per study (project leads, data managers, technical/admin personnel) gives 200 to 400 individuals for the questionnaire population. The email corpus separately captures a comparable or larger number through senders and recipients beyond the roster. eForm entry: 400 (a plain number; the field doesn't take a hyphenated range).

5 E. Recruitment

Where fixed: recruitment.qmd, line 36 (voluntariness) and line 38 (REB file number).

States that participation is voluntary and that declining or withdrawing has no bearing on the participant's standing with, or any past or future collaboration with, the CITF Databank. REB file number filled in (was a placeholder), #26-08-029.

6 F. Consent Process

Where fixed: ethics-protocol.qmd, Consent process section (lines 32–48, 55–63).

The waiver rationale addresses each of the six TCPS2 Article 5.5A criteria, numbered 1 to 6 in the text since eRAP fields don't render markdown: necessity of identifiable information, low risk to participant welfare, privacy and security safeguards, compliance with known prior preferences, impracticability of seeking consent, and permissions obtained for secondary use.

Impracticability: the email corpus and the questionnaire's recruitment pool are substantially different populations. The corpus draws on correspondence from a small number of CITF Databank operational roles and incidentally captures a much larger, more heterogeneous

set of senders and recipients, many no longer contactable. The questionnaire’s roster-based recruitment reaches a narrower, more current population. The two are treated as analytically parallel and non-overlapping, compared only through abstracted categories, by design.

Undue influence: the PI holds no personal, financial, or professional interest that would constitute a conflict of interest. CITF funding for the partner studies represented among questionnaire participants has concluded, and the PI holds no ongoing funding or collaboration authority over them. Zachary Batist, Postdoctoral Researcher, conducts all participant-facing recruitment and consent activities and holds no authority over CITF funding or collaboration decisions.

7 G. Risk/Benefit Assessment

Where fixed: ethics-protocol.qmd, Risk-benefit assessment section (line 73).

Participant contact information now names Zachary Batist instead of the principal investigator, matching comment F’s mitigation.

8 H. Confidentiality and Data Security

Where fixed: ethics-protocol.qmd, Privacy and confidentiality section (lines 99–101).

Access to the unobfuscated email backups is limited to Zachary Batist, David Buckeridge, and Research Assistants on the email processing pipeline. No other CITF Databank personnel have access. Backups are deleted at project completion; only de-identified data is retained after that.

9 I. Conflicts of Interest

Where fixed: ethics-protocol.qmd, Managing conflicts of interest section (line 131).

Remains “Not applicable.” The eForm’s explanation field may only be accessible if “Yes” is selected. The substantive reasoning, no personal/financial/professional interest and funding concluded, is written into the Consent Process section (comment F) so it’s in the submission regardless of what the Conflicts of Interest page allows.

10 J. Additional Documentation

No action required.

11 Other fixes, not tied to a lettered comment

informed-consent.qmd: REB file number placeholder (“xxxx”) filled in with #26-08-029, line 72. Principal researcher contact (Zachary Batist) was already correct. No other edits made yet; full consistency check against this memo’s other changes still outstanding.

index.qmd: “data managers” capitalized to “Data Managers,” line 63, matching the Databank-operational-role convention used in ethics-protocol.qmd. REB file number added to the opening paragraph, line 31: “conducted under McGill REB file #26-08-029,” not “approved under,” since approval is still pending.